Blue to Blue

Death and the Desire to Continue

Ellie Su

Revised manuscript

Contents

The Fear 5

Part 1 The First Wound 7

1 The First Grave 7
2 The Animal That Knows 10
3 Wanting Forever 11

Part 2 The Self That Wants to Survive 12

4 What Is the Self 12
5 Memory Is Not the Soul 16
6 The Stream of Awareness 19
7 The Tuesday Problem 21

Part 3 The Universe Without Us 24

8 The Displacement 24
9 The Body as Process 26
10 The End of Experience 27
11 The Failure of Forever 29

Contents

Part 4 Answers to Death **31**

12 The Ancient Dead 33
13 Judgment and Reunion 35
14 Karma, Rebirth, and Liberation 39
15 No Self and Rebirth 42
16 The Dead Who Stay Near 44
17 The Dao, Cycles, and Water 49
18 The Materialist Answer 50
19 Nothing Matters 52
20 Living with the Absurd 54
21 What We Owe One Another 56

Part 5 A Life Still to Live **59**

22 The Scale Problem 59
23 Attention 62
24 Love 65
25 Work, Creation, and Legacy 68
26 What Suffering Does Not Teach 71
27 Becoming 73
28 No Final Answer 76

Notes on the Poems 79

Notes and Sources 80

Poems

Red Ocher 9
The Boat I Wake In 14
The Two-Year-Old Is Gone 18
The Room After 20
Tuesday 23
The Witness 25
The Garden 31
The Fire Exit 37
Candle to Candle 41
The Color of Salvation 46
No Ledger 58
Small Evidences 61
Vigil 63
Because You Will Go 67
The Seed That Stayed 70
I WILL BE THAT I AM 74
The Morning You Stayed 77
Blue to Blue 78

PREFACE

The Fear

When I try to imagine being dead, I leave myself in the picture. I imagine darkness, then someone enduring the dark. I imagine silence and continue listening. However carefully I remove the world, I keep someone there to notice that it is gone.

I am frightened of losing that person. I mean the one having this experience, remembering this life, asking the question now. It is difficult even to describe what I want preserved without giving it another name, such as a soul, and seeming to have answered the question already.

Memory was where I began. If I woke in another life remembering nothing of this one, what would make it mine? I still find that question troubling. But I would not say that ordinary forgetting makes someone a different person, and I need to understand why I treat forgetting across death differently.

I have wanted to believe religious promises of continuation. Wanting has never supplied the belief. My own expectation is that conscious experience ends when the brain permanently loses the capacity to support it. I do not regard this as a completed explanation of consciousness. It is the account I find most convincing, including when I wish I did not.

Being told that something of me will remain rarely reaches the fear. Someone might remember my name. A sentence might affect a reader. The matter in my body will enter other arrangements. I understand why these continuations matter to the living. I cannot yet see how any of them becomes another experience for me.

Then the question changes. If I cannot keep an experience forever, why have I started to doubt that it matters now? A pleasant afternoon becomes difficult to value because I imagine a future in which no one remembers it. I have allowed

that imagined future to pass judgment without asking what gives it the right.

The poems sometimes argue with the prose. Their speakers can be angry, frightened, or more certain than I am. I wanted to hear what happened when those voices were allowed to finish speaking. The book begins with a grave, where someone had to decide what to do with a body.

PART 1

The First Wound

1

The First Grave

About 78,000 years ago, someone buried a child at Panga ya Saidi in Kenya. The child was about two and a half to three years old. Researchers identified an intentional burial from the position of the remains and the way fragile joints had stayed together, evidence that the body had been covered soon after death. [1]

I can picture someone arranging the child. I cannot recover what that person thought they were doing. Care, fear, custom, a hope of another life: more than one motive could have been present. The bones give us evidence of an action. The words that may have accompanied it are gone.

We cannot point confidently to the first grave. An earlier burial may have left no trace we can recognize. Even if we found it, the beginning of burial would not necessarily be the beginning of grief or belief. It is tempting to make this one act explain too much, especially when it seems to bring an enormous history within reach.

There is already enough to wonder about in the body itself. A face can remain recognizable after the person has stopped answering. The living have to decide what to do with someone they can still see and can no longer reach. Belief in a surviving soul gives one reason to treat the body carefully. I do not need that belief to feel that the body deserves more than disposal. This was how the person lived among others, how they could be held and hurt. Their death does not erase that history.

That is how I understand care for the dead. It is not something I have discovered about the people at Panga ya Saidi. I would be making the same mistake if I used their grave to prove that religion began when frightened people invented a place for the dead to go. The wish for a simple origin can outrun the evidence as easily as the wish for an afterlife.

For now, there is the child and the deliberate burial. Someone responded to this death. I do not know what they hoped would happen next.

Red Ocher

Crushed stone clings to the creases
of her palms. Iron settles in the lines.

He is folded now
in ways he never folded when
the fire still answered his name.
Knees to chest. Arms crossed.
Chin tucked like a child
pretending sleep.
She does not close his eyes.
Something else has done that.

The ocher pours between her fingers.
She paints the hollows of his throat,
the arches of his feet,
the spaces where his wrists
used to turn the flint blade over
to show her the good side.

She finds the shell,
broken on one side.
It will not hold water.

She sets it in the cup of his hand
the way she might have set
honeycomb beside his sleeping mat
for morning.

The grave will close
around his hand.

She stands.
The ocher dries on her palms.
Her hands are still shaking
over someone who will never wake
to find the shell.

The shell stays.
And the dark does not refuse it.

2

The Animal That Knows

Fear can arrive long before danger. I can make plans for next week and, in the same minute, wonder whether there will be any experience at all after my death. Nothing has to happen in the room. The thought is enough to change how it feels to be there.

I am reluctant to call this a uniquely human burden. Other animals cannot tell me what they anticipate. Fleeing a threat, recognizing that a body has stopped moving, and understanding that one's own life will end are different capacities. Evidence for one does not automatically establish the others, and a lack of words gives us limited access to them all.

In controlled presentations of objects, African elephants showed more interest in elephant skulls and ivory than in comparison objects. The researchers did not establish that the elephants recognized a particular relative's skull. The animals' attention is observable; exactly what that attention means remains uncertain. [2]

I do not know what a deer anticipates in the dark. I can watch it sleep or lift its head at a sound. Neither action tells me the whole of its experience. Describing its life as simple might make my own fear feel exceptional, but that would be a poor reason for believing the description.

What I can examine is the way my knowledge of death enters a life that is still going on. It can make an ordinary plan feel precarious. It can also give a promise a longer reach: I can try to do something for a person who may outlive me. The thought has no fixed emotional result. Sometimes it makes care urgent; sometimes it makes every effort feel pointless. Knowing the same fact does not keep me from responding to it differently.

The difficulty is partly that I can think about my absence while having no experience of it. I know there was a world before I was born. I expect it to continue after I die. Yet the only world I can encounter is the one I am alive to encounter. I keep trying to look beyond that limit from within it.

3

Wanting Forever

When I ask for an afterlife, more time is only part of what I want. I want the people I love to be there, and I want us to recognize one another. I want to finish things I have begun. An eternity with no connection to this life might preserve consciousness while losing most of what makes the prospect attractive.

Other hopes complicate the wish. Reunion is different from justice. Meeting someone again would not necessarily repair what had been done to them. A judgment might promise that suffering will be answered while making the future more frightening. Even endless life leaves open what sort of life it would be and whether I would still want it.

I can understand the appeal of a promise without being able to believe it. This has been my difficulty with religion. Fear gives me a reason to want reassurance, but it cannot supply the conviction. I can repeat an answer, wish it were true, imagine how much easier it would make the night. The question of whether it is true remains.

Nor does the wish count against it. A belief can comfort someone and still be right. I would gain very little by replacing the wish to be comforted with the wish to think of myself as unusually honest. Enduring an unpleasant conclusion does not make the conclusion more accurate.

There is a difficulty in the wish itself, before any evidence is considered. I want to keep living partly because I want to change. I want to learn things I do not know and make work I cannot yet make. But I also want the person who does those things to be me. An entirely unchanging future would barely resemble a life; a future with no connection to this one would seem to belong to someone else.

That is what I need an account of survival to explain. How much can change before the promise no longer preserves the person to whom it was made?

PART 2

The Self That Wants to Survive

4

What Is the Self

My name would be easy to preserve. So would a photograph. Neither is what I mean when I say I want to keep living. The difficulty begins when I try to say exactly what is missing from them.

The word I can refer to my body, the life I remember, the person other people recognize, or the perspective from which I am thinking now. Usually these stay together well enough that I do not need to sort them out. Death forces the question because each might continue, or fail to continue, in a different way.

One distinction is between resemblance and being the same individual. Two copies of a book remain two books even if every word matches. Numerical identity asks whether we are dealing with one individual at different times or with different individuals who resemble one another. It would matter if a future being had my face and every memory I now have. Resemblance alone would not tell me whether I had survived.

Then there is the life I understand as mine. I can abandon an ambition or feel ashamed of something I once believed without thinking that another organism used to inhabit my body. The change can be so large that I say I am a different person. In ordinary speech, that can describe how I feel about my past without settling whether the earlier person literally ceased to exist.

John Locke distinguished the continuing life of a human organism from the consciousness through which a person takes past actions as their own. His account of identity also concerned responsibility: who should receive praise or

punishment for an act? The question of who someone is has consequences beyond what they remember about themselves.[3]

Care cannot depend on solving that puzzle. An infant does not need a life story to deserve protection. Someone who has lost the ability to tell their story still needs to be met as a person. A theory about what connects different stages of a life does not, by itself, tell us whose suffering matters.

When I ask whether I survive, I am asking whether there will be a later experience I can look forward to as mine. This does not require imagining a little observer hidden behind the brain. It requires explaining the connection between the person anticipating a future and the person who will live it.

The Boat I Wake In

How long does it take to become another?
I have drowned so many sheets of me
in bathtubs, in bedsheets, in the salt
of someone else's shoulder.

The hull was wood. Now it is bone.
Now the bone has been replaced with steel.
No. Still bone. But younger bone.
But the younger bone is not the same.

The plank my anger splintered one winter,
that door, that furious oak,
someone planed it down
and painted over it.

I cannot find the dent.
I remember the dent.

But the dent was in the wood,
and the wood is gone.

Memory falls out like old rope.

I wake and a name is missing:
the cousin with the bicycle,
the street that bent left toward the river,
the word for the feeling after crying.

I write them down. I lose the paper.
I find the paper. I do not know my handwriting.

Each morning I walk down to the dock
and find a boat.

Same length. Same scratch
on the port side? No,
that scratch was starboard.
Or was that the last boat?

The name on the bow is freshly painted.
The paint is still wet.

I touch it. It smears.
I wipe my finger on my shirt.

The shirt was not mine yesterday.

When I climb in, the boat holds.
That is enough.
That is not enough.

I want the original plank.
I want the hand that carved the mast
before I knew what losing was.

But I am the boat that leaves the dock,
and I am the boat that returns,
and between leaving and returning
every board was replaced,
and still I say I,
and still I am lying,
and still I am not entirely wrong.

5

Memory Is Not the Soul

Someone can tell me what I did on a day I have forgotten. I may believe them and still feel that the day belongs to me differently from one I remember. In remembering, I have the feeling of having been there, of recognizing the event as part of my own life. This is why an afterlife without memory can seem to leave out the person I hoped it would save.

Yet I forget things without believing that I have ceased to be the person who experienced them. If every memory had to remain available, much of my life would already belong to strangers.

Thomas Reid made the difficulty precise. A young officer remembers an experience from childhood. Later, as a general, he remembers being the officer but has forgotten that childhood experience. If the general is the officer and the officer is the child, the general must also be the child. A rule requiring direct memory would deny that last connection. An account based on overlapping continuity avoids this problem without requiring the general to remember everything. [4]

Memory can also fail selectively. Scoville and Milner's 1957 study described severe impairment of recent memory after certain bilateral medial temporal operations, while earlier memories, technical skills, and general intelligence could remain. The loss was profound, but it did not erase every capacity at once. [5]

A forgotten event can still belong to the history that shaped a person. Being unable to recall it is different from having no connection to it. This makes my objection to memoryless survival harder to state. I cannot use ordinary forgetting as proof that a new person has appeared. I can still ask whether a proposed afterlife preserves anything that connects it to the life I know.

The question becomes painful when recognition fails between people. A loved face is no longer familiar, and

something in the relationship has been lost. But the person who cannot recognize it may still feel comfort or fear. Care has to reach that present experience, even when shared recollection is no longer possible.

I want memory to survive because so much of what I want lies in it. That is different from making it the sole test of whether I exist. I might remain alive through a change that takes away much of what I had hoped another life would preserve.

The Two-Year-Old Is Gone

In the album, pressed against a page
gone tacky with old glue,
a handprint the size of a mouse.
Blue paint. Thumb smeared sideways.
Someone wrote a name and a year
in cursive I cannot enter.

I do not remember the afternoon,
the paint, the paper,
the small hand pressing itself into proof.

I look at the handprint and feel
the strange politeness of recognition:
that was me,
as if I am identifying a cousin
seen once at a funeral.

In the photograph, the child squints
at a camera someone aimed from the hips.
I try to bring back the voice,
the fear of the vacuum,
the way they bit their lower lip
while stacking blocks.

Nothing comes.

The paint is still blue.
The hand is no hand I remember wearing.

And if forgetting is death,
I have died so many times already
that heaven would be a room
full of children I cannot name.

6

The Stream of Awareness

Death is sometimes compared to sleep. The reassurance depends on leaving waking inside the picture. If I expect to wake, the interruption belongs to a life that continues. Remove that expectation and the comparison offers much less.

Even while someone is alive, the absence of response does not settle whether experience has stopped. Anesthesia researchers distinguish consciousness, connection to the surrounding environment, and the ability to respond. These can come apart. A later failure to remember an interval also cannot establish, by itself, that the interval contained no experience. [6]

Changes in the brain can alter a person's access to their own life. The selective losses described by Scoville and Milner give one example: an operation on neural tissue can change what a person remembers. [5]

Someone who believes in a separate soul could accept this and suggest that the brain receives or expresses consciousness. A damaged receiver can distort a signal without destroying its source. I can follow the analogy. What I would need next is evidence of the proposed source and some account of how it preserves a person after the brain can no longer function. The receiver image gives me a possibility to consider, not a reason to expect that I will survive.

For now, I expect conscious life to end when the brain permanently loses the capacity to support it. There is still the question of why anything feels like anything. Describing the conditions in which experience occurs has not answered it. I can leave that difficulty unresolved without treating it as evidence for an afterlife.

The word stream can make this seem easier than it is. I picture something flowing through moments, and then begin to imagine that the flow must have somewhere else to go. But the metaphor has added that destination. What I know from within is the experience happening now. Whether another moment follows depends on more than my ability to picture a current.

The Room After

The switch clicks down:
brass against brass,
a small authority surrendering its office.

The ceiling holds its white.
The chair does not lean into shadow.
The table stands on four legs,
the cup keeps its lip,
the window frames the yard:
grass, fence, lower branch of oak,
a bird that did not notice
the difference between on and off.

The absence on the wall is only a nail.
The silence on the sill is only dust.

The carpet continues its weave.
The crack in the baseboard continues
its slow migration toward the corner.

The switch is down.
The wires rest.
The bulb does not grieve its filament.

On the shelf, the photograph:
a woman turning from the doorway,
one hand still on the knob,
caught in the instant before leaving.

Paper, ink, a silver frame.
The hand stays on the knob.

7

The Tuesday Problem

Suppose I die on a Tuesday. Wednesday can still come. Other people can wake and have experiences, and much that belonged to my life can remain in theirs. What has happened to the person whose last day was Tuesday?

This is the difficulty I call the Tuesday problem. Being told that something continues is reassuring only if I know what the something is. A name, an influence, and a later experience are very different answers to the wish that I should survive.

Consider a snake eating a mouse. Material from the mouse becomes available to the snake. Describing that as continuation does not show that the mouse acquires the snake's next experience. It shows what can go wrong when material persistence is offered as personal survival. It tells us nothing decisive about a proposed soul or another account of what connects lives.

A perfect psychological copy is harder. Suppose a machine copies me while I remain alive. The copy remembers my childhood, but what it sees in another room does not automatically enter my experience. Destroying the original during copying would not settle whether the person left was that individual. Two equal copies make the problem sharper. If both were the original, they would have to be the same individual as each other. Yet there are two. Derek Parfit examined related branching cases and argued that what matters in survival may remain even when identity does not give the answer we expect. Perhaps memory, intention, and affection are enough. My demand for an additional owner of the future could be the mistake. [7]

I cannot dismiss that objection merely because I find copying unsettling. Nor would the copy's life be worth less because it failed to reassure me. Still, I would want to know what I should expect while the machine was working. Should I

anticipate waking as the copy? What would make that anticipation justified?

Memoryless rebirth raises a different question. After admitting that forgetting does not necessarily end a person, I cannot reject rebirth just because its subject remembers nothing. I need an account of what connects the lives. A continuing soul or a causal succession might supply such an account, if there were reason to believe it. The snake and mouse do not refute a claim about something other than recycled matter.

I keep returning to the word mine. I want to know why a later experience would be mine, yet I cannot point to a separate thing that owns experience. There is a felt connection from one moment to another. Whether that feeling identifies something that can survive death is still the question.

Tuesday

All morning the field held its gold:
foxtail, milkweed, the last thin grass
that forgot to go brown.

Then the fire came from the east.
It walked through the stems like a hand
closing a drawer.

The gold became orange.
The orange became black lace.
The black lace lifted on its own heat
and scattered into the sky.

A cricket stopped mid-song.

By noon, the field was ash and silence.
Each flake a map
of the stem it once climbed.

The wind rearranged the maps.

A child watching from the road
said pretty without meaning to.

PART 3

The Universe Without Us

8

The Displacement

Thirteen point eight billion years is a number I can write down. I cannot really imagine its duration. It is approximately the age of the universe inferred from Planck measurements within the standard cosmological model, an estimate tested against observations and subject to the model's uncertainties. [8]

My first response to that scale is often to feel that my life scarcely counts. Then I notice what I have done: a measurement of duration has become a judgment of importance. I have assumed that a longer history makes a stronger claim on me. A telescope can tell me about distance; it cannot establish that whatever is furthest away matters most.

I call the feeling displacement, although no center has been taken from me. The scale was there before I learned to picture it. The room in which a worry fills the evening becomes a point that vanishes when I pull back. When I return, the worry is still waiting. I know something that changes the way I see the room, and I still have to live in it.

The Witness

I don't keep your secrets.
I just can't speak.

That heart you carved?
Scar tissue now.
The girl who kissed it?
Maggot food under my roots.
You still run your thumb along the bark,
looking for your names.

You come here to feel small.
You are small.
A beetle's lifespan with louder shoes.

The ash beside me took eighty years
to reach your upstairs window.
You cut it down for more light.
Burned its branches through the winter,
split its trunk for firewood.
Come April, you planted a sapling
beside the stump, photographed your hands
in the dirt, and called it healing.

The sapling died in July.

At night my branches listen to the wind
carry your shouting from the house
with the blue door, the sound of tires
on gravel, the boy screaming your name
from the ditch beside the highway.
I watched your headlights turn away.
By morning the rain had washed
his footprints from the shoulder.
I drank what reached my roots.

I don't weep sap for you.
Sap is for leaves.
You are just carbon I haven't stolen yet.

One day you'll walk under me
during the wrong storm.
A branch, rotting where you cannot see,
will give under its own weight.
Your skull will feed a mushroom.
I'll forget by spring.

9

The Body as Process

A body does not stay alive by keeping everything it has. It takes in food and air, repairs itself, and lets material go. Even sitting still depends on this activity.

The claim that the whole body replaces itself every seven years would make a tidy illustration. It is false. Different cells have different histories. A study using radiocarbon to date human cells found neurons in the adult occipital cortex about as old as the individual, while nonneuronal cells were exchanged. There is no single schedule on which the whole person becomes materially new. [9]

Some parts can persist while others are replaced. The persistence of a life therefore cannot be reduced either to keeping the original material or to replacing it. A river is a useful comparison only up to a point. The changing water does not have to explain how it remembers, anticipates, or experiences its own movement. A person does.

Death also resists being pictured as the instant when every part stops together. Death by neurologic criteria is a clinical determination involving permanent loss of function of the brain as a whole, including the brainstem, under defined conditions. Being unresponsive is not enough to establish it. Nor does it mean that every cell in the body has died at the same time. [10]

What concerns me is the loss of the organization that makes a conscious life possible. Material can remain after that organization is gone. Calling it part of the same body does not tell us whether anyone can still experience through it. This is why the survival of my body's materials would answer so little of my fear.

Yet the wish to preserve myself unchanged has its own difficulty. A living future would require continued activity and alteration. I want another day in which something can happen to me. I cannot also require every detail of the person who enters it to remain fixed.

10

The End of Experience

If consciousness ends permanently at death, there is no later experience of being dead. That rules out the endless blank I sometimes imagine enduring. It leaves open whether death can still be a loss.

Epicurus argued that death should not trouble us because good and evil depend on sensation, and death ends sensation. We never encounter it: while we are present it has not arrived, and once it arrives we are gone. The argument removes the imagined observer trapped in darkness. Whether it removes the harm of death depends on its premise about what can be good or bad for someone. [11]

Thomas Nagel challenged that premise. Death can be bad, on his account, because it deprives a person of a life they could otherwise have had. Being dead need not feel unpleasant for the lost possibilities to matter. The comparison is between the life that occurred and the life that might have continued. [12]

I can want another year because I want to live it. I do not have to imagine watching it from outside my life. More time might contain suffering as well as things I want, so the comparison is uncertain. Calling death a loss does not mean every possible extension would be welcome.

I have also thought that, from my own perspective, I am always alive. There is a truth in the sentence: every experience I have occurs while I can experience. But it says nothing about whether there will be another one. A series can end without containing an entry that announces its ending from within. My inability to experience my own absence gives me no reason to expect immortality.

Time would not stop with my awareness. Other clocks and other lives could continue. Nor would I find the next century passing instantly before I woke somewhere else. If the ending were permanent, there would be no later moment from which I could judge how any interval had felt.

The fears begin to separate. Pain during dying, leaving someone who needs me, and losing a future are different from imagining myself condemned to conscious isolation forever. An argument against that last picture cannot dismiss the others. I can believe there will be no one left to endure death and still want next year.

11

The Failure of Forever

If I cannot continue, perhaps something I make will. A name might be remembered; work might reach someone I will never meet. These hopes ask less than an afterlife, but I can feel myself trying to make them do the same work.

They have their own conditions. A text needs a reader, a medium that survives, and some way of remaining available. Outlasting its maker does not free a thing from the possibility of being lost. Moving the hope from a person to a civilization gives it more time, perhaps, without establishing that it can last forever.

Entropy often enters the discussion as though physics had already decided whether any effort was worthwhile. Its constraint is narrower. The total entropy of an isolated system does not decrease in an ordinary macroscopic process. Local order can increase through exchanges with the surroundings while the total balance satisfies the law. Living organisms are open systems; their continued organization is compatible with thermodynamics. [13]

The law does not decide whether to write something or help someone. It describes conditions within which those actions occur. Knowing that an arrangement is temporary cannot tell me, by itself, whether to preserve it a little longer.

Nor can I borrow a final scene from cosmology and treat it as settled. A universe approaching thermal equilibrium is one possible long-term picture under particular assumptions. The nature of dark energy remains incompletely understood, and NASA connects that uncertainty to the difficulty of predicting the ultimate fate of cosmic expansion. [13,14]

My difficulty does not require every trace of a life to disappear. Even an archive that lasted indefinitely would leave the question of who experiences its contents. Information about me is not automatically an experience I can have. And if

the archive lasted only a century, its loss would not show that nobody had benefited from it while it was there.

Forever would be a poor test of what deserves preservation anyway. An injury could be prolonged, or a pointless task repeated without end. I would still need to explain why I wanted a particular thing to continue.

If someone reads these words after I die, I hope they find something worth thinking about. The experience will be theirs. I do not expect to be there to know whether I helped.

PART 4

Answers to Death

The Garden

The children are trying to open life
as a fruit in summer,
hacking through the green skin
to reach the red.
They lick the sweetness from their fingers,
run their tongues along their teeth.

Do relish, children.
The branches bend low for you;
the figs split open at a touch.
Take the ripest ones. There will be leaves
enough to cover what you cannot bear to see.
Let the sweetness run down your wrists.
There is plenty.
Have I not always given freely?

Do lie, children. Hide your stories
in loveliness.
Tear the fruit open, fill your shining mouths,
go laughing through my garden,
building little towers from the bones you break,
then crown yourselves with pretty names.
For a long time, I called it play.

Even lilies choke each other for sunlight.
I watched you weave the thorns into garlands,
place them on each other's heads,
then wonder at the blood.

Still you come bearing your little offerings,
stolen blossoms, bruised and wilting,
as though I had not heard the earth beneath you
crying out for what you buried there.
At night you kneel among the roots
and ask me to make your hands clean.

Would you have thanked me for forever?
I could have left you in the branches,
softening past sweetness, unable to fall,
until the flesh gave way around the seed
and nothing living wanted you.

I have not always hated you.
Once, I counted every bud that opened,
kept the frost from finding you at night,
and bent the branches toward your reaching hands.
When the wood began to split,
I told myself you were only hungry.

I have given you enough for a lifetime.
I took the bone from your sleeping side,
made flesh of it, and called it good.
I had not thought those hands would learn
to draw blood from what was once their own,
to carry it beneath their fingernails.

When winter comes, you will beg
for the fruit to grow back.
You will call me cruel for letting it come,
though your hands stripped the branches bare.

Remember, then, that I was merciful.
Do not come with me.

And when the dust takes you back,
do not ask why I made you.

12

The Ancient Dead

In the underworld of Homer's Odyssey, Odysseus tries to embrace his dead mother. Three times she escapes his arms. He recognizes her and hears her speak, yet cannot hold her. Later, Achilles says he would rather work for a poor man on earth than rule over all the dead. Survival in this poem leaves much of what made life desirable out of reach. [15]

The failed embrace bothers me. If I could recognize someone again but never touch them, would the reunion relieve the loss? I might spend it trying to do exactly what Odysseus does. The person would be there, and I would still want them back.

In Spell 125 of the Egyptian Book of the Dead, the deceased faces judgment before Osiris. The heart is weighed against a feather associated with maat, the divine order of truth and justice. Declarations denying wrongdoing accompany the judgment. Death leads into a moral and ritual order in which the life already lived must be answered for. [16] Here I find another wish I understand: that what happened to a person should not simply be forgotten when the people involved are gone. But punishment would not necessarily repair the injury. Even if a wrongdoer could be brought before such a court, what could it restore to the person harmed?

It is tempting to say that frightened people invented these worlds because they needed somewhere to go. That explanation is too easy. A belief can be comforting and true, or frightening and false. Its appeal tells me something about why I might want it; it gives me little reason to accept or reject its account of death. Fear alone cannot supply a history of how it arose, either.

The details are persuasive in another way. A place with a road and a judge is easier to imagine than the end of imagining. I can furnish it with voices and gestures, then begin to feel that it must exist because I have managed to picture

myself there. The text has made somewhere I can enter as a reader. Whether anyone enters it after death remains unanswered.

I return to Odysseus reaching for his mother because the scene allows the promise to fail at the very moment it seems fulfilled. He has found her and can hear her answer him, yet keeps trying to hold her, as though the existence of another world had left his grief unfinished.

13

Judgment and Reunion

I can understand wanting another conversation more urgently than an explanation of the universe. I have tried to find religious belief through the comfort it might offer. Wanting that comfort never made me believe. It did, however, make the promise of reunion difficult to dismiss.

Jewish scripture contains very different accounts of death. Ecclesiastes describes the dead as knowing nothing and Sheol as without work or knowledge; Daniel imagines sleepers in the dust awakening, some to enduring life and others to shame. [17,18] Later, in the Mishneh Torah, Maimonides describes the world to come as an incorporeal life of souls. His is one influential interpretation within a tradition that also preserves other accounts of resurrection and the future. [19]

Paul's account in 1 Corinthians 15 centers on a transformed, imperishable body. His “spiritual body” is not simply a ghost escaping embodiment. The body is raised and changed, which leaves me asking what connects that body to the one that died.[20] The Qur'an answers a related question about decayed bones by referring to their first creator: the one who created them can restore them. Another passage tells those who have wronged themselves not to despair of divine mercy. [21,22]

Trust in God may be enough for a believer to cross the gap between a body dying and a person being restored. I am still at the first premise. An all-powerful creator could presumably preserve me, but I would need a reason to believe that such a creator exists and has made this promise. Imagining how it could be done is easier than believing it will happen.

Judgment appeals to a different part of me. Cruelty can succeed. A person can die without acknowledging what they did, while the people they harmed spend their lives with the consequences. I understand wanting someone to answer for that. Yet a promised judgment has to survive the questions I would put to any account of justice. Why should a finite life

incur endless suffering? What happens to someone whose inability to believe was honest?

Christians disagree about the fate of the condemned. Eternal conscious punishment, eventual destruction, and universal reconciliation are different answers. My objection to endless torment does not apply in the same way to all three. [23]

What I cannot make sense of is perfect happiness alongside a loved person's permanent torment. If heaven required me to accept that suffering as deserved, what would have happened to my love for them? I might be wrong about what justice requires. But the assurance that I would understand later would be asking me to trust a future self whose peace I can scarcely recognize as my own.

Fear makes this harder to examine. The possibility of punishment can make an honest failure to believe feel like a dangerous act. A warning might make me say the right words. I do not see how it could make me know that they are true.

And if I did arrive in heaven, would I still be allowed to want the missing person there? I cannot picture that reunion without wondering whom I would have to stop missing to be happy.

The Fire Exit

the church could hold two hundred people.
a brass plate beside the door said so.
in winter, the saints in stained glass
cast blue and violet shadows across our knees,
and the women in the kitchen saved me
the corner pieces of cake
because they knew i liked the icing.

i liked it there. i liked being known.

one winter, snow melted from our coats
into dark circles on the carpet.
our pastor wept halfway through his sermon,
his white sleeves trembling beneath the wooden cross.
later, my mom said he was frightened
because when he looked at us, our chapped lips
and restless hands, he could see our faces in hell.
one misplaced word could lead us there.

i believed him because he was afraid.

because i was afraid.

afterward, i began worrying about my grandmother.
on saturdays, she called from a kitchen full of steam.
i could hear her slippers scuffing the floor,
the kettle hissing, the little scrape of her thumbnail
beneath a mandarin's skin. she asked whether i had eaten,
whether i was sleeping enough. sometimes she laughed
so hard her voice broke into static.

i tried to imagine the fire reaching those hands.
each time i got as far as her thumb slipping beneath the peel,
the white threads clinging to her fingers.

i practiced telling her about jesus.
when she called, i asked about the weather.

once, during a fire drill, the alarm split the last hymn in half.
the organ held its note a moment after everyone
had stopped singing. a little boy crawled beneath the pews
for his lost mitten. our pastor lifted him into his arms,
one small foot kicking against his coat.

i remember the emergency doors, how the silver bar
gave way beneath my palm, how rain rushed in
and darkened the carpet at our feet. the old women went first,
then the children, then our pastor, carrying the boy
whose mitten he had tucked into his pocket.

outside, the gutters overflowed. our breath rose in little clouds,
and someone passed a blanket around. the pastor knelt
to tie the boy's shoe, his wet sleeves brushing the pavement.
i remember how gently he held the ankle.

there had been no fire.

we went back inside.

one sunday i woke to the bells and stayed in bed,
the sheets still warm around my knees. for an hour
i waited for something terrible to happen.
downstairs, my mother was washing dishes.
i could hear the water running.

i stopped going. i stopped praying.
sometimes, passing a church, i still felt the old panic
rise behind my ribs, as though somewhere
a child were calling for help.
years later, i still count the exits whenever i enter a room.
i look for the red illuminated letters, the hinges,
the worn silver bars.

sometimes i am the last to leave.
the lights go out, the footsteps fade,
and cold air slips beneath my sleeves
as i stand holding the heavy door.

my grandmother would tell me to come inside
before i caught cold. i can hear exactly how she would say it,
impatient, laughing a little, asking why i always worry so much.

there is nobody left inside.

i know this.

still, i hold the door.

14

Karma, Rebirth, and Liberation

At first, reincarnation seems to offer exactly what I want: another life. Then I try to put myself in it. If the person there remembers nothing of this life, loves different people, and never recognizes the things I am afraid of losing, what makes that future mine?

The Bhagavad Gita begins with a different account of the self. In 2.20, the self is unborn and undying; in 2.22, changing bodies is compared to exchanging worn garments for new ones. What endures is deeper than the remembered biography I usually mean when I say me. [24] My memory objection does not simply defeat this claim, since the claim already places the self elsewhere. I have to ask why I should believe in that enduring self.

Hindu traditions disagree about its nature. Advaita Vedanta understands the true self through the nonduality of brahman, while Dvaita Vedanta maintains a real distinction between individual selves and God. These differences also affect what liberation can mean. In influential traditions, samsara, the cycle of birth and death, is something from which one seeks moksha, or liberation. Repetition itself can be the predicament.[25]

I approach reincarnation hoping death might be interrupted. A teaching concerned with liberation may instead ask why I want the cycle to continue. That is an uncomfortable reversal. The wish that brought me to the teaching may be one of the things it asks me to give up.

The problems with memory from the earlier chapters remain. Forgetting alone does not prove that someone has ceased to be the same person. But rebirth asks me to accept a connection across different bodies and lives. What carries that connection, and what reason do I have to believe it occurs? Giving it a name leaves those questions open.

Even if I accepted the connection, I would have another difficulty. Much of what I want from a future concerns the people and experiences I know now. I want to recognize them. A life that preserved a subject while losing every attachment might count as survival under a particular theory. I am less sure it would answer the person who was hoping to survive. The disagreement would then concern what makes survival desirable, as well as what makes it possible.

Karma raises a further worry for me. If consequences extend beyond the lives we can see, how could I know enough about a particular sufferer to say they had earned their pain? An unseen past can become an explanation I never have to check. I could use it to make an injustice seem deserved while doing nothing about it. I would rather admit that I do not know why this happened to someone than turn that ignorance into a reason to withhold help.

Candle to Candle

The first candle bends its flame
to touch the second wick.
The second, in its turn, sends light
to light a third.

Does the first flame survive?

The second burns
with the same tongue,
the same hunger.

The first wick curls.
A thread of smoke
passes through the light
the second candle gives.

15

No Self and Rebirth

The question I keep asking is what will happen to me. The Buddhist texts I am reading are less willing to let that last word pass.

In the discourse commonly called the Anatta-lakkhana Sutta, the Buddha examines form, feeling, perception, volitional formations, and consciousness. Each changes; none can simply be commanded to become what one wishes. None should be taken as an enduring self or possession. The analysis questions the unchanging owner I imagine behind experience. It does not make suffering imaginary or ordinary persons unimportant. [26]

Rebirth becomes harder to picture without a permanent owner. In the Mahatanhasankhaya Sutta, Sati claims that the same consciousness travels through rebirth. The Buddha rejects his claim and describes consciousness as arising through conditions. Within this teaching, continuity belongs with dependence, rather than with an identical consciousness moving intact between lives. [27] I can follow the idea of one event conditioning another. The step I cannot follow is from the changes of this life to a connection with a life after death. What provides that connection?

Nor does final liberation give me an answer in the terms I expect. In the Aggi-Vacchagotta Sutta, the Buddha declines to affirm that a liberated one after death exists, does not exist, both exists and does not exist, or neither. [28] I find the refusal frustrating. I want to know whether experience continues, and the discourse will not accept the alternatives I have brought to it. Calling nirvana either personal immortality or annihilation would settle the question by ignoring that refusal.

There is also a limit to what karma is asked to explain. In the Sivaka Sutta, the Buddha rejects the assertion that everything a person feels results entirely from previous action. Bodily

conditions and harsh treatment are among the other causes of painful experience. [29]

I am drawn to the thought that demanding permanence makes change harder to bear. Yet wanting someone to remain alive can also involve concern for their life. I would need to learn how to separate that concern from my demand that I never lose them. Describing every wish to continue as grasping would make the distinction too easy.

Perhaps examining the self would change what I fear. It might show me that I have been trying to preserve something I cannot even locate in the life I am living. But I still want another experience. The question about an owner has unsettled me; the wish has not disappeared.

16

The Dead Who Stay Near

After someone dies, there may still be a sentence that only they would understand. There may be news whose first destination was always that person. The impulse to tell them can remain, with nowhere obvious to go.

During Qingming, families may tend graves, make food offerings, and burn incense or paper money in remembrance of the dead. The practice gives remembrance something to do, though the actions alone cannot tell me what each participant believes an offering accomplishes. [30] The Analects describes Confucius sacrificing to the dead as though they were present, and emphasizes his participation in the rite. [31] That phrase leaves room for questions about belief. It does tell me something about the attention the act requires.

Being remembered is not the continuation I want when I fear my own death. Another person's recollection would not become a place from which I could watch them. Still, a memory can carry a responsibility. Someone may have entrusted us with work or told us about a wrong that others would prefer forgotten. What we remember can change what we do after they are gone.

Suppose a religious community welcomes you on the understanding that your family's offerings must now be called foolish or corrupt. Its sacred images receive reverence, while the food your relatives place before the dead counts against them. You are asked to explain your family's love in a language that has already judged it. I would want to know why one set of gestures was permitted dignity and the other was treated with contempt.

I do not have to believe the dead can hear in order to recognize the care involved in preparing something for them. That recognition also need not bind me to everything a family has handed down. A person can leave tenderness and harmful expectations to the same descendants. We may receive a story

worth keeping alongside an instruction we cannot accept. The people who inherit them will have to decide what to do with both.

Honoring the dead can therefore require disagreement. Continuing someone's care may take a form they would not have recognized; refusing an inherited cruelty may be part of making a family safer for those still in it. The dead cannot revise the instructions they left. The living should be able to question them without being accused of forgetting where they came from.

The Color of Salvation

in sunday school, they gave us jesus
in a black outline, his arms extended
towards the little children gathering
at his feet. i colored his skin peach,
his hair the yellow of a summer field,
his eyes the blue of the stained glass
above our heads. i pressed so hard
the crayon broke at the neck.
i hid the pieces beneath my palm,
careful not to color outside the lines.

on the chapel wall, another jesus
hung above the baptismal pool,
his pale, immaculate hands reaching
towards a world that seemed to have
forgotten where he came from.
someone had washed the judean dust
from his feet, brushed the desert
from his skin, dressed him in angel white
and given him the face
of the people who owned the church.

our pastor told us water washed
everything clean. the jordan, he said,
was where it all began, though here
it came through silver faucets,
filtered, heated, poured into a tiled basin
behind the pulpit, where little children
learned to drown for a moment
in the name of salvation.

my grandmother used to cut mooncakes
into quarters, the knife sinking through
sweet lotus paste, the salted yolk
resting in its center like a small,
unbroken moon. she told me of chang'e,
who swallowed immortality and rose
beyond the reach of everyone she loved.
i used to wonder whether the jade rabbit
kept her company.

once, i asked the pastor
whether my grandmother would go to heaven.
he asked if she had accepted christ.
i told him about the mooncakes,
the incense curling from her windowsill,
the little stories she had given me
before i learned to call them false.

he said there would be no false gods
in the kingdom of heaven.
behind him, jesus watched us
with his borrowed blue eyes.
i wondered why they could give their god
another face, another language,
another country to call his own,
while my grandmother could not
even keep her moon.

he said he would pray for her.

i learned of men who preached another kingdom
from houses built on cotton and sugarcane.
their silver was polished by hands
that would never own it.
servants, obey your masters.
the lord has prepared a place for you.

there was a bible made smaller
for the enslaved, much of exodus
lifted from its spine until moses
could no longer lead anyone out.
there was still room for obedience,
for masters, for trembling.

and in the spirituals, moses still led
the people out. the missing water
returned in human throats.

on sunday, i watched another girl
descend the little white steps
into the baptismal pool. the pastor
placed one hand against her back,
the other over her folded fingers,
and lowered her beneath the surface.

for a moment, the water trembled.
the painted christ's reflection fractured,
his blue eyes scattered across the tiles,
his golden hair unraveling
into thin, uncertain threads.

when she rose, everyone applauded.
her mother held out a white towel,
and the pastor told her
she had been made new.

the water settled.
jesus had his face again.

i wanted to reach into the pool,
to trail my fingers through the surface,
to see how many times
i could break him apart
before they asked me to stop.

outside, the moon was rising,
whole and white above the chapel.

i thought of my grandmother's knife,
of the sweet lotus paste giving way,
the yolk divided into quarters.

17

The Dao, Cycles, and Water

In a story in the Zhuangzi, Huizi visits after Zhuangzi's wife has died and finds him singing and beating a basin. Zhuangzi explains that he grieved at first. Then he considered the transformations through which breath, form, and life arose, and death as another change, like the succession of seasons. [32] I find the initial grief important. He had to arrive at the singing. It was not his first response to losing her.

This story cannot stand for all of Daoism. Daoist traditions also include deities, ritual, and pursuits of longevity or immortality. Even the familiar division between philosophical and religious Daoism obscures connections within that history.[33]

I understand the wish to widen the frame. My body was never sealed off from the world, and its materials will not remain arranged around me forever. Water makes this easy to picture. It fills a cup, leaves it, and enters somewhere else. Nothing in that movement tells me whether I will experience the next change. I would have to look for another kind of comfort in the image.

How much loosening is possible? I want a way to be less frightened, but I do not want to become indifferent to a life ending too soon. Calling death natural cannot decide what I ought to welcome. Illness is natural too, and I still have reasons to care for someone who is ill.

Zhuangzi's story is more difficult if I let the loss remain in it. He has found a way to regard his wife's death that makes the singing possible. I cannot take his response and turn it into a timetable for someone else's grief. A mourner would have to arrive there, if they arrived there at all.

For me, accepting a death might mean learning to remain in a world I still wish were different. I can see why a person would need to do that. I am less certain how it becomes a song.

18

The Materialist Answer

I expect my conscious life to end when my brain irreversibly loses the capacity to sustain it. This frightens me. It also seems more convincing than the accounts of survival I have considered. The dependence examined earlier in this book gives me a reason for that expectation. It does not prove that every imaginable form of existence beyond death is impossible.

Physicalism includes different accounts of how everything is ultimately physical or dependent on the physical. Thoughts and relationships need not be unreal on such an account. The difficult question is how experience belongs to it. Calling myself a materialist does not provide a finished explanation of consciousness. [34]

Why should a physical process feel like anything from within? I do not know. A description of what the brain does can leave that question pressing, but the unanswered part does not point by itself to a separable soul. I would need evidence for that answer too. Possibility gives me room to reconsider; it cannot give every proposed afterlife the same claim on my belief.

I also distrust the word merely when it appears in an account of the body. If love depends on physical events, why would it be counterfeit? The feeling happened, and the person it concerned was real. Learning more about the conditions that made it possible would not erase the difference it made. The claim that something is physical needs another argument before it can become the claim that the thing has no value.

What the materialist account removes is the imagined witness enduring an endless absence. On this view, there would be no one left to wait, to miss the world, or to count the time. That corrects one picture of death. It leaves the loss of the experiences I wanted, and the wish that someone who died

could be here again. That expectation does little to weaken the wish for more time.

I might change my mind about survival if I had reason to. Until then, I cannot plan around another opportunity after death to finish what was left between two people. Nor can I assume that someone treated cruelly will receive compensation elsewhere. If I owe someone an apology, I have to consider the possibility that I may run out of time to give it.

19

Nothing Matters

When I am frightened, “I will die” and “nothing matters” can feel like the same thought. Written down, they are two claims. I need a reason to get from one to the other.

There are different questions inside the word meaning. One concerns a purpose for the universe; another concerns meaning within a life. Philosophers also disagree about whether a meaningful life depends on what a person cares about, on activities worthwhile independently of that preference, or on both. Naturalistic accounts seek an answer without requiring God or immortality. [35] An answer about the universe's purpose cannot simply be carried over to every question about the lives within it.

Suppose I say that nothing finite can matter because it will eventually be forgotten. Why must someone remember an event forever for it to have been significant when it occurred? If a pain ends, I am relieved. Its ending does not make the hours before it negligible. It would be strange to require permanence of what is good while readily accepting that a brief suffering can be terrible.

The word really troubles me here. I can say that something matters to a person, then dismiss it because it does not really matter. What is missing from the first claim? If I mean that no one outside the universe has approved it, I still have to explain why that approval is required. Repeating that we will all die does not supply the explanation.

There is a harder objection. Someone can care intensely about a destructive purpose. Feeling committed to a project does not justify what the project does to others. If meaning is whatever I happen to want, how could I distinguish a life of care from a life organized around domination? Telling everyone to invent a purpose leaves this problem untouched.

That is where the question of meaning begins to involve other people. Their lives can place demands on what I choose

even if no purpose was assigned to me at birth. I need reasons that can survive being questioned by someone who will bear the consequences of my choice. Enthusiasm alone will not do.

I may accept all of this and still feel that nothing matters. An argument cannot make an attachment return on command. But I want to be able to admit that I feel no meaning at a particular moment without deciding that I have discovered the final truth about everyone else's life.

20

Living with the Absurd

The gods condemn Sisyphus to roll a stone uphill and watch it fall again. In The Myth of Sisyphus, Camus follows him on the descent, conscious of the punishment to which he must return. The labor was imposed. His awareness of it, and the possibility of happiness within it, are what Camus asks us to consider. [36] I understand why the descent interests him. I find the happiness harder. Knowing exactly what was happening would not, I think, make me happy.

Camus's absurd concerns the confrontation between our demand for intelligibility and a world that does not satisfy it. It is the unresolved relation between them, rather than a claim that everything is simply strange or pointless. His later work, The Rebel, takes up solidarity and the limits rebellion must recognize in its treatment of others. [37] The refusal of a final explanation still leaves the question of how to treat the people beside us.

I want to be careful about making endurance admirable. Some burdens can be removed, and someone may benefit from pretending they are inevitable. If an employer can reduce a dangerous workload, I would ask why they have not done so before asking whether a worker has found meaning in it. A person's ability to endure should not let anyone else evade that question.

Even with a limit that cannot be changed, I would read the possibility of happiness as a possibility, not an obligation. I can want to live and resent the conditions of being alive. On another day I might become absorbed in something and forget that resentment for a while. Neither response has to settle the matter. Requiring the right attitude all the time would give me another burden to carry.

I am still drawn to the wish for an explanation that would make everything fit. Cruelty would somehow become intelligible from a distance; my own ending would belong to a

purpose. But I distrust how easily such a distance can be claimed. An explanation that satisfies the person offering it may leave the person who suffered with everything still to bear.

I may never understand why a world capable of suffering exists. That is a reason to be careful about the explanations I give someone else, especially when they would make me feel better about leaving that person to suffer.

21

What We Owe One Another

When I am in pain, I do not require a theory of the universe before I want help. If another person asks the same of me, why should their pain count for less simply because it is theirs? I cannot find a defensible reason to give my own experience that privilege. The difficulty begins when our needs conflict and I have to decide what taking both seriously requires.

There is a commitment here that I cannot prove just by describing a nervous system. I take another person's suffering to be a reason to act, and I have to defend that choice through consistency and attention to the people affected. Someone who refuses every such reason presents a real problem. Invoking the universe's approval would not persuade them unless that approval could itself be justified.

Nor is reducing suffering the only thing I need to consider. People have wishes about their own lives. Consent and freedom matter, especially when it is someone else's loss I am proposing to accept for a benefit I will receive. The affected person may understand a cost I have overlooked. Their account belongs in the decision, rather than arriving afterward as an objection to a plan already made for them.

The Amsterdam Declaration of 2022 expresses a contemporary humanist commitment to dignity and freedom, responsibility toward others and future generations, and concern for sentient beings. It also treats ethical judgment as open to reasoning and revision. [38] I find this useful because the commitments are stated plainly enough to argue with. They are choices to defend, not results that follow automatically from science.

Future people cannot negotiate with me now, though my choices may shape the world they inherit. Nonhuman animals cannot describe their suffering in my language. Those limitations make it easier to overlook them; they do not give

me a reason to disregard their experience. Familiarity is a poor basis for deciding whose life counts.

All this makes care more demanding than following a strong feeling. I have to look for consequences I would rather overlook and listen when someone says I have misunderstood what they need. Good intentions will not settle that disagreement. Sometimes taking the other person seriously will mean admitting I was wrong and stopping what I thought was helping.

No Ledger

You wash the cup.
The lip is stained.
Tomorrow someone will drink from it.

You bandage the cut
on a stranger's hand.
The stranger will not remember your face.
The bandage will fall off in water.

You sit beside the bed.
The one in the bed does not know you are there.
The clock ticks.
The window darkens.
Your back hurts from the chair.

You do not leave.

PART 5

A Life Still to Live

22

The Scale Problem

I can make myself disappear by changing the scale of a thought. Start with the room, then the building, then the town. Keep going until the Earth is too small to see. Nothing has happened to the room, yet its contents have become difficult to take seriously.

Why should that view have the last word? Thomas Nagel asks a related question in ‘The Absurd’: would being larger, or living longer, explain why a life matters? If a distant future can cancel present concerns, we need to explain where it gets that authority. The feeling of absurdity survives his objection, but some familiar arguments for it do not.[39]

A change of scale can help answer one question while making another impossible to ask. To explain how a hand moves, I might look at muscles and nerves. To understand why someone withdrew their hand from mine, I need to know something about us. More magnification will not reveal the broken promise. The bodily account and the account of the relationship concern the same event, but I need different information from each.

The distant view leaves out almost everything by which I distinguish care from cruelty. That makes it a poor guide to choosing between them. I have been mistaking the loss of detail in a picture for the discovery that the detail never mattered.

Of course, closeness can distort things too. I can care intensely about a project that makes someone else miserable. Their objection may force me to reconsider it. But they can tell me what it costs them; they have something to show me that my own enthusiasm concealed. The statement that the

universe is large offers no comparable account of what I have got wrong.

Longer timescales help when they reveal consequences. A decision convenient for me now may leave someone else with years of difficulty. I ought to look far enough ahead to notice that. Looking past everyone affected, until no one is visible, serves a different purpose. I am no longer learning more about the decision.

I have wanted the universe to tell me that my life counts. I cannot say what would count as its reply. When someone asks me to keep a promise, at least I know what I am being asked.

Small Evidences

Rain on the sill.
A dish left drying,
its blue rim still beaded.
One shoe beside the other,
not quite straight.
Window filmed with breath
from a pause before speaking.

The kettle cools.
The clock ticks a minute
no one will remember.

Someone watches the rain
run down the glass,
watches the dish forget its use,
watches the shoe wait
for a foot that is already home.

23

Attention

The same garden can be watched by someone waiting for it to flower and by someone waiting to cut down anything that grows out of line. Both notice changes. Attention alone tells me very little about what they will do.

I can watch someone closely to learn which response will win their agreement. I can notice a bird only long enough to make it an image of my loneliness. Looking harder will not help if I have already decided what everything must mean. I may become very observant about the details that suit me.

Simone Weil connects the patience of study with attention to another person's suffering. Her account is religious: the difficult exercise trains an attention also required in prayer. She warns against reaching for an answer before we have allowed the problem to become clear. I recognize the impatience she describes, even though I do not share all the beliefs behind her argument.[40]

Reading a poem can expose that impatience. An empty chair suggests absence, and I hurry toward grief. But someone might have stood up to open the window. I need to read the next line. The chair may turn out to belong to a poem quite different from the one I began composing for it.

This is difficult for a book so preoccupied with death. A tree, a passing cloud, a half-finished cup can all be made to speak about mortality. Eventually I risk finding the same thought everywhere because I have stopped giving anything a chance to surprise me. The branch may have fallen for reasons that have nothing to do with the person watching it.

I am also tired of the instruction to notice every moment before it disappears. It turns attention into another performance to fail. Some hours are dull. Some tasks are worth doing quickly so there is time for something else. Wanting to stay alive does not oblige me to be fascinated by every minute.

The harder work is allowing what I encounter to change my mind. Sometimes I need to stay with a question longer. Sometimes I need to notice that the person beside me wants to stop answering it.

Vigil

I.

One opens too loud.
Cut.

One reaches for rain.
Cut.

One stem leans left.
Cut.

Now the bed is quiet.
Soil still turns.
The edging holds.

Visitors say restful.
You nod.

At night you walk the rows,
checking for the one
you might have missed.

II.

You missed me.

I learned to close
at the sound of your footsteps,
to turn my face
before you saw
which way I wanted the sun.

I thought the point of flowering
was to be seen.

So each time something opened
I cut it while it was beautiful
and left it in your hands.

One new shoot.
Cut.

One unopened bud.
Cut.

You smiled.

After a while,
you stopped bringing the shears.
You didn't need to.

Now the bed is quiet.
The edging holds.

At night I walk the rows,
checking for the one
I might have let grow.

24

Love

Loving fewer people would seem to make death easier. There would be fewer names I dreaded seeing on a screen, fewer voices whose absence could change an ordinary day. The protection would begin immediately, along with the loss it was meant to postpone.

I cannot decide whether that bargain is worthwhile by counting only the grief a relationship may cause. I would also have to count the years in which the other person was alive. What happened during them? What did we make possible for each other? A future separation does not tell me how to answer.

Nor does fear of separation tell me how to love someone now. Wanting to keep a person can become wanting to keep them unchanged. I want the familiar voice and the habits I understand. They may want something that disrupts the account I have made of us. Their life continues beyond what I know of it, even while we are together.

There is a difficulty here that no promise of eternity would remove. If I only want another person on the condition that they remain recognizable to me, how much of their life am I prepared to let them have? This is different from agreeing to their death. It concerns whether I can bear their having a future I have not written.

Care is often much less dramatic than the fear of losing it. The same question needs answering again. Someone is taking longer than expected, and I wait. I may be impatient or tired while doing something they need. The action need not produce a revelation about love to be worth doing.

Of course, a relationship can also make a life smaller or more frightening. Mortality is no reason to remain in one that does that. Being needed cannot settle what I owe, especially when another person uses their need to make every refusal

feel cruel. Love has to leave room for the life of the person offering it too.

The hope of reunion still reaches a wish that none of these arguments can replace. I understand wanting another conversation with one particular person. Telling someone that the body's atoms continue answers a different question. I have no promise to put in its place.

I am left with what it is like for the other person to be alive today. They may need help with something ordinary. They may want to be left alone. I have to ask.

Because You Will Go

The knife follows the mango's stone.
Your hand steadies the peel.
You cut it carefully
because she likes the yellow cubes
and her hands shake now.

The car idles in the clinic lot.
You wait.
The clock on the dash is wrong.
You do not fix it.
You watch the door.

You fold the laundry into squares:
his shirts, your hands,
the same motion
you learned from your mother
who learned it from hers.
The fabric is warm from the dryer.
Soon it will be worn,
then dirty,
then warm again.

The pills sit in seven small cups,
Monday through Sunday.
You check the morning cup twice.
No one thanks you for the checking.
No one has to.

25

Work, Creation, and Legacy

I like teaching because an explanation exposes what I do not understand. Preparing a lecture on mass conservation meant thinking carefully about how to make the mathematics understandable to someone else. A step that seems obvious becomes difficult when I have to say why it follows. Sometimes I discover that I have been carrying a sentence around in place of a reason.

There is a particular satisfaction when an argument finally becomes clear to both people. Neither has to discover a theorem. Something we could previously only repeat can now be understood. I would have trouble explaining why that exchange mattered if I began by asking who would remember our names in a thousand years.

Much of what I want from work happens while I am doing it. A question resists the first approach. An error forces me to go back. When an explanation gets simpler, I can sometimes see that I have understood more, rather than merely left something out. A useful result matters, but reaching it is an experience too.

Even if mathematical truth is timeless, understanding a proof does not make me timeless. The proof might outlast every record of its author. That would preserve something the author worked on; it would not give the author another afternoon. I can admire the permanence and still fail to find the consolation I was looking for.

A poem offers a less certain kind of continuation. Someone may read the words after the writer has died and misunderstand nearly everything. They may also find something the writer did not know was there. The page has to make the encounter possible without its author standing beside every line to explain the intention. This is a reason to work carefully on it. Wanting to reach someone is only the beginning.

The wish for a future audience can become oppressive. If I ask a piece of work to protect me from disappearing, an ordinary audience will never seem large enough. A finished project will not settle the question for long. I will need another, and then another. Curiosity can turn into a frantic attempt to produce evidence that I deserve to have been here.

A more useful question is what the work needs. An argument may need to be abandoned because it is wrong. A poem may need fewer lines, including the line I most wanted someone to admire. Accepting that is easier when the thing I made is allowed to be separate from my claim on a life.

I want people to read what I write. I would like to leave explanations someone can use. I also want to have understood something myself, during the time in which understanding is still possible for me.

The Seed That Stayed

She pressed it into April soil:
thumb deep, then covered.
The landlord sold the lot in June.
She moved three states away.

Roots split the sidewalk where
she used to sit with coffee.
Children climb the tree now.
They do not know
who made the shade.

An apple falls,
rolls toward a stranger's hand,
and the stranger eats.

26

What Suffering Does Not Teach

Grief deepens love. Pain makes happiness possible. Claims like these give suffering a job, and a world in which every injury has a job can seem less arbitrary. But the injured person is then expected to be grateful for the result.

Someone may become more attentive after being neglected. That does not make neglect a good way to teach attention. Whatever they learned required a response of their own, perhaps against the example they had been given. Calling the injury a gift credits the wrong thing.

The argument from contrast has limits too. Hunger can make a meal especially welcome. A child still does not need to be abandoned before companionship can be good. Some pleasures grow sharper through comparison; that is a poor basis for deciding how much another person ought to suffer.

Poverty is easily made picturesque. A bowl containing very little can reflect the sky. A poem can notice the reflection, then move on to something else. The person who needs a meal cannot necessarily move on. If I use the bowl as an image of spiritual freedom, I have to account for the freedom I possess as a writer to stop thinking about its emptiness.

Money cannot settle the question of mortality. It can pay for food, a place to live, or a way out of a dangerous situation. Its failure to answer one question says little about its usefulness in answering another. Criticizing wealth does not require treating deprivation as a form of wisdom.

I have a similar difficulty with the claim that death makes life precious. A deadline may change how I use an afternoon. Shortening it would not therefore improve it. I can become more attentive to the time I have while still wanting more time. There is no inconsistency to repair by declaring the loss beneficial.

Effort complicates the question. Learning a difficult passage of music can be frustrating, and some frustration may be

unavoidable if I want to play it. That does not make the amount of pain a measure of how much I have learned. I may need to rest, or to admit that the method is not working. Chosen difficulty also gives no one permission to impose an injury and promise that it will make me stronger.

I want to leave room for a loss from which nothing useful emerges. Someone may live with it for years, do generous things, and still wish it had never happened. That wish need not be a failure to find the lesson.

27

Becoming

How much change am I willing to survive? I want to learn things I cannot yet understand and make work I cannot yet make. Those wishes require a future person who differs from me. Yet I also want to be able to recognize her.

Ordinary change is not death. I live through the loss of an old belief or the decision to give up a plan. An unrealized possibility was never another person waiting somewhere to be killed. The language of small deaths can express the pain of choosing, but sometimes it makes the choice seem more final than it is. I can return to something. I can discover that I misunderstood what I had given up.

Other choices do close. A year spent on one pursuit cannot also be spent on every other one. Silence can preserve a comfortable misunderstanding until it becomes difficult to correct. Waiting does not keep every option available. I am changing during the wait.

I also began with a language I did not choose and expectations I learned before I could examine them. Some possibilities are expensive; others are unavailable. To call my life entirely self-authored would conceal how much of the page was already occupied. Still, what I inherited may be something I can question. A description that was once accurate need not be an instruction to repeat it.

I distrust the relief of finding a final sentence about myself. It can make a choice feel settled before I have tried it. It can excuse silence: this is simply the kind of person I am. But I am also the person deciding whether to rely on that description again.

A commitment leaves me less protected. I can promise to be honest without knowing every truth I will be reluctant to tell. I will have to find out what the promise asks of me when the occasion arrives.

I WILL BE THAT I AM

I.

The seed does not count loss to split its coat,
nor does the root, blind, in its downward coil.
A contract written in the dark, a note
that says: to take the air, you spend the soil.
Before the leaves can whisper I am,
the root must find its way without a name.

For every future self we choose to be,
some other self must go unlived, unknown.

My mother taught me how to hold a knife,
to turn the blade away from where I stood.
My father taught me how to mend a wing
before I learned that not all broken things
could be restored. Neither gave me words
for all the grief that waited past their own.
I took the offered tools in trembling hands.

II.

The green, grasping nerve works up the trellis,
binds to a frame, and learns
a pattern larger than one leaf.

The child I was still walks the roads I left,
still turns toward doors I passed without a word,
still lives the lives I never could have lived.
I cannot bring her with me everywhere.

III.

At Moses' feet, the thornbush burned, unspent.
A voice spoke from the fire: I AM THAT I AM.

I used to hear a stone inside those words,
a name complete, untouched by grief or time.
But even there, the voice came clothed in flame,
and I was wrong to make a stone of it.

I cannot speak so wholly of myself.
Each time I say I am, my breath has moved.

Not what I am, the attribute, the name
that pins me to a category, but that
I am at all: the bare and burning fact,
a fire that does not spend
the bush it feeds on.

IV.

I make the vow before I know its cost,
for my own sake
and for the sake of those I will not meet.

And still, to give that life a name is risk.
To speak is to be heard, perhaps mistaken;
the shoot must break the dark to leave the ground.

Death may arrive before the work is done.
The tree need not behold its farthest branches,
nor know whose hands will gather what it bears.
Its rings remember winters it has weathered;
where one limb broke, new wood grows round the scar.
Above it, leaves still rustle in the wind.

V.

I will not be the sum of all my chances,
the lives I left, the names I did not claim.
I am the one who chose, and bears the choosing,
who loses something each time something grows.

The coat splits open. Root takes hold below;
the shoot, still folded, rises toward the sun.
The seed gives up its shape to bear its fruit.
The life it was is lost, but not undone.

And I, still growing, answer what I am:

I will be that I am.

28

No Final Answer

I still want more time. The distinction between being dead and experiencing darkness has not made me willing to give up the conversations I have not had or the things I might understand later.

I expect my experience to end when the brain permanently loses the capacity to sustain it. I have found no account of an afterlife that I can honestly adopt. There are questions about consciousness I cannot answer, but I cannot fill them with a future simply because I want one.

What has changed is the work I expect an answer to do. I hoped that understanding death might make the fear stop interrupting me. An argument can correct a mistake without removing the feeling attached to it. I may have to remember the argument again. I may be persuaded by it and afraid at the same time.

I have also asked too much of the things I love. A conversation cannot compensate for every conversation I will miss. A poem cannot become an indestructible version of its writer. If I require those things of them, they will always fail. I would like to give them a chance to be good at something smaller.

There will still be wasted afternoons and opportunities I recognize too late. I do not want to spend the rest of my life proving that I appreciated it enough. Wanting more time is not a privilege earned by using every previous hour well.

I want to get back to questions I have not finished thinking about. There are people whose company I want. I do not expect the fear to disappear when I return to them.

The Morning You Stayed

The kitchen at dawn,
your sleeve brushing mine
while the kettle took its time.

You did not check your phone,
did not rush the toast,
did not fill the silence
with anything but bread and butter.

I sat beside you.
The window showed the same fence
it showed yesterday.
The clock ticked the same way.

You did not know
I was memorizing you.

You poured the tea,
slid the cup across the table,
and stayed.

Blue to Blue

Rain washes away memories,
soft as a thumb erasing chalk.
Streets slick with the ghosts of footsteps,
gutters humming a tune I almost forgot.

Each puddle a small, trembling mirror.
I look in and see someone else.
The clouds have no use for names,
just keep drifting, empty as bells.

By dusk, the scent of wet iron
and cut grass. A child's torn shoe
on the curb. Nothing grieves here,
only water returning to water,
blue to blue.

Notes on the Poems

Red Ocher. The burial is imagined. Its shell, honeycomb, and gestures do not reconstruct a particular archaeological find.

The Garden. The poem draws on the rib and the return to dust in Genesis 2–3, the blood crying from the ground in Genesis 4:10, and the crown of thorns in Matthew 27:29.[41]

The Color of Salvation. The abridged Bible was published in London in 1807 for enslaved people in the British West Indies. It omitted much of the Exodus liberation narrative and retained material stressing obedience. The University of Glasgow holds a copy. Museum of the Bible also discusses the use of Exodus in spirituals. The poem places these histories together without reconstructing a particular singing scene.[42,43]

I WILL BE THAT I AM. The title reworks Exodus 3:14 as a personal vow. Its words are the poem's own, rather than a proposed translation of the Hebrew.[44]

Notes and Sources

1. María Martinón-Torres et al. *Earliest known human burial in Africa* (2021-05-05), Abstract and taphonomic interpretation of the Panga ya Saidi child; DOI 10.1038/s41586-021-03457-8.

2. Karen McComb, Lucy Baker, Cynthia Moss. *African elephants show high levels of interest in the skulls and ivory of their own species* (2006-03-22), Abstract and experiments 1–3; Biology Letters 2(1):26–28; DOI 10.1098/rsbl.2005.0400.

3. John Locke. *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding, Book II, Chapter XXVII: Of Identity and Diversity* (1694), Sections 4–9, 17–18 and 26. Chapter added in the second edition, 1694.

4. Thomas Reid. *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man, Essay III, Chapter VI: Of Mr. Locke's Account of Our Personal Identity* (1785), Essay III, chapter VI; the brave officer example. Overlapping psychological continuity is offered here as a response to the objection, not as Reid's own solution.

5. William Beecher Scoville and Brenda Milner. *Loss of recent memory after bilateral hippocampal lesions* (1957-02), Summary and conclusions; Journal of Neurology, Neurosurgery, and Psychiatry 20(1), 11–21; DOI 10.1136/jnnp.20.1.11.

6. Robert D. Sanders, Giulio Tononi, Steven Laureys and Jamie W. Sleigh. *Unresponsiveness ≠ Unconsciousness* (2012-04), Abstract and distinctions among consciousness, connectedness and responsiveness; Anesthesiology 116(4):946–959; DOI 10.1097/ALN.0b013e318249d0a7.

7. Derek Parfit. *Personal Identity* (1971-01), The Philosophical Review 80(1):3–27; opening discussion and sections I–II on branching, identity and survival; particularly journal pp. 3–9.

8. Planck Collaboration (N. Aghanim et al.). *Planck 2018 results. VI. Cosmological parameters* (2020-09), Base-ΛCDM parameter estimates, Table 2; Astronomy & Astrophysics 641, A6.

9. Kirsty L. Spalding, Ratan D. Bhardwaj, Bruce A. Buchholz, Henrik Druid and Jonas Frisén. *Retrospective birth dating of cells in humans* (2005-07-15), Abstract; Cell 122(1):133–143; DOI 10.1016/j.cell.2005.04.028. Occipital cortex neuron and nonneuronal cell comparisons.

10. David M. Greer et al. *Pediatric and Adult Brain Death/Death by Neurologic Criteria Consensus Guideline: Report of the AAN Guidelines Subcommittee, AAP, CNS, and SCCM* (2023), Introduction and Concept of Brain Death/Death by Neurologic Criteria; DOI 10.1212/WNL.0000000000207740.

11. Epicurus; translation by Robert Drew Hicks. *Letter to Menoeceus* (c. 300 BCE), Sections 124–125, paragraphs on sensation and death.

12. Thomas Nagel. *Death* (1970), Opening argument on deprivation; Noûs 4(1):73–80.

13. Paul Peter Urone and Roger Hinrichs; OpenStax. *College Physics, §15.6: Entropy and the Second Law of Thermodynamics: Disorder and the Unavailability of Energy* (2012), Second Law of Thermodynamics Restated in Terms of Entropy; Life, Evolution, and the Second Law; Heat Death of the Universe.

14. NASA Science, Physics of the Cosmos. *Expand our Knowledge of Dark Energy* (n.d.; accessed 2026-11-08), Final main paragraph: unknown nature of dark energy and limits on predictions of cosmic fate.

15. Homer; translated by Samuel Butler. *The Odyssey, Book XI* (1900 translation), 11.204–224 and 11.488–491.

16. Fitzwilliam Museum, University of Cambridge. *Spell 125: Osiris and the judgement of the dead* (n.d.), Book of the Dead, Spell 125.

17. Hebrew Bible; English translation presented by Mechon Mamre. *Daniel, Chapter 12* (n.d. online edition), Daniel 12:2.

18. Hebrew Bible; English translation presented by Mechon Mamre. *Ecclesiastes, Chapter 9* (n.d. online edition), Ecclesiastes 9:5–10.

19. Moses Maimonides; translated by Eliyahu Touger. *Mishneh Torah, Repentance, Chapter Eight* (n.d. online edition), Hilchot Teshuvah 8:2.

20. Paul; New American Bible, Revised Edition, United States Conference of Catholic Bishops. *1 Corinthians, Chapter 15* (1986 New Testament translation; 2011 NABRE edition), 1 Corinthians 15:35–54.

21. Qur'an; parallel English translations presented by the Quranic Arabic Corpus. *Quran translation: Chapter 36, Verse 79* (n.d.), Qur'an 36:78–79.

22. Qur'an; parallel English translations presented by the Quranic Arabic Corpus. *Quran translation: Chapter 39, Verse 53* (n.d.), Qur'an 39:53.

23. Thomas Talbott, Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *Heaven and Hell in Christian Thought* (Revised 2025-05-10), Introduction and discussion of eternal punishment, annihilation, and universal reconciliation.

24. Bhagavad Gita; translated by A. C. Bhaktivedanta Swami Prabhupāda. *Bhagavad-gītā As It Is, Chapter 2, Verses 20 and 22* (n.d. online edition), Bhagavad Gita 2.20 and 2.22. The garment comparison is in verse 2.22: https://vedabase.io/en/library/bg/2/22/. Prabhupāda's translation belongs to a Vaishnava interpretive tradition.

25. Shyam Ranganathan, Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *Hindu Philosophy* (n.d.), Sections on karma and moksha; Vedanta, especially Advaita and Dvaita.

26. Saṃyutta Nikāya; translated by Thanissaro Bhikkhu. *Pañcavaggi Sutta: Five Brethren (Anatta-lakkhana Sutta)* (1993 translation), SN 22.59.

27. Majjhima Nikāya; translated by Thanissaro Bhikkhu. *Mahatanhasankhaya Sutta: The Greater Craving-Destruction Discourse* (2011 translation), MN 38, Sati's view and the account of conditioned consciousness.

28. Majjhima Nikāya; translated by Thanissaro Bhikkhu. *Aggi-Vacchagotta Sutta: To Vacchagotta on Fire* (1997 translation), MN 72, the four alternatives concerning the Tathagata after death.

29. Saṃyutta Nikāya; translated by Thanissaro Bhikkhu. *Sivaka Sutta: To Sivaka* (2005 translation), SN 36.21.

30. National Museum of Asian Art, Smithsonian Institution. *Qing Ming Festival* (n.d.), Educational overview, description of grave tending and offerings.

31. Confucius and his transmitters; translated by James Legge. *The Analects: Ba Yi* (n.d. online edition), Analects 3.12.

32. Zhuangzi, received text; translated by James Legge. *The Writings of Zhuangzi: Perfect Enjoyment* (1891 translation), Chapter 18, section 2; parallel text also at https://ctext.org/zhuangzi/perfect-enjoyment. Legge renders qi as breath.

33. Ronnie Littlejohn, Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *Daoist Philosophy* (n.d.), Introduction; discussion of Daoist traditions and their historical development.

34. Daniel Stoljar, Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *Physicalism* (Revised 2026-09-16), Introduction and discussions of formulation, consciousness, and the case for physicalism.

35. Thaddeus Metz, Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *The Meaning of Life* (Revised 2026-06-26), Distinction between meaning in a life and cosmic purpose; naturalism and nihilism.

36. Albert Camus; English excerpt hosted by the University of Central Arkansas. *The Myth of Sisyphus, concluding section* (1942 original French essay), Concluding section, the punishment and Sisyphus's descent.

37. Ronald Aronson, Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. *Albert Camus* (Revised 2021-12-13), Discussions of The Myth of Sisyphus and The Rebel.

38. Humanists International. *The Amsterdam Declaration* (2022), Sections 1 and 2.

39. Thomas Nagel. *The Absurd* (1971), The Journal of Philosophy 68, no. 20, pp. 716–727, especially section I.

40. Simone Weil. *Reflections on the Right Use of School Studies with a View to the Love of God* (written around 1942; collected in 1950), Waiting for God, translated by Emma Craufurd; essay on study, attention, prayer, and love of one's neighbor.

41. Bible. *The King James Version of the Bible* (King James Version), Genesis 2:21–23; 3:7 and 3:19; 4:10; Matthew 27:29.

42. University of Glasgow, Beniba Centre for Slavery Studies. *Slave Bible* (collection item published in London in 1807), Call and Response exhibition; University of Glasgow Library, Sp Coll Euing Da-g.23.

43. Museum of the Bible. *Slave Bible in the 1800s* (24 September 2018), Account of omitted Exodus passages and the continuing use of Exodus in spirituals.

44. Hebrew Bible. *Exodus 3:14* (translation consulted: New Revised Standard Version Updated Edition), Exodus 3:14 and its translation note. The translation note includes both present and future renderings.